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Modeling and Control of Cable-Driven UAV Systems for Collaborative Load Manipulation

Jury

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Abstract

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Notations

$F_0(O, x_0, y_0, z_0)$	Inertial reference world frame
$F_p(P, x_p, y_p, z_p)$	Platform reference frame at its center of mass
$F_i(A_i, x_i, y_i, z_i)$	Quadrotor reference frame at cable connection
$F_{C_i}(A_{C_i}, x_{C_i}, y_{C_i}, z_{C_i})$	Quadrotor reference frame attached to the quadrotor at its center of mass
$F_k(A_k, x_k, y_k, z_k)$	Ground vehicle reference frame

Abbreviations

ACT	Aerial Cable Towed
ACTR	Aerial Cable Towed Robot
ACTS	Aerial Cable Towed System
AW	Available Wrench set
CDPR	Cable-Driven Parallel Robot
DKM	Direct Kinematic Model
DoF	Degree of Freedom
IKC	Inverse Kinematic Controller
INDI	Incremental Nonlinear Dynamic Inversion
MPC	Model Predictive Control
NMPC	Nonlinear Model Predictive Control
OCF	Optimal Control Problem
ORCA	Optimal Reciprocal Collision Avoidance
rAW	Radius of the Available Wrench
SAW	Static Available Wrench set
SW	Static workspace
UAV	Unmanned Aerial Vehicle
UGV	Unmanned Ground Vehicle
VIC	Variable Impedance Control
WFW	Wrench Feasible Workspace

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Introduction

This thesis work takes place in the context of the ShieldBot project, which aims to revolutionise the construction, renovation, and maintenance sectors by investigating and validating a new generation of robotic systems tailored to the industry's unique challenges [1]. The Shieldbot project focuses on three complementary robotic solutions:

- InnerShieldBot is designed for internal construction works to enhance the thermal performance of walls and ceilings.
- InspectionShieldBot is dedicated to identify structural or insulation needs, and ensure long-term building integrity.
- FaçadeShieldBot is designed to operate on building façades and install thermal shielding in order to improve insulation and reduce energy consumption.

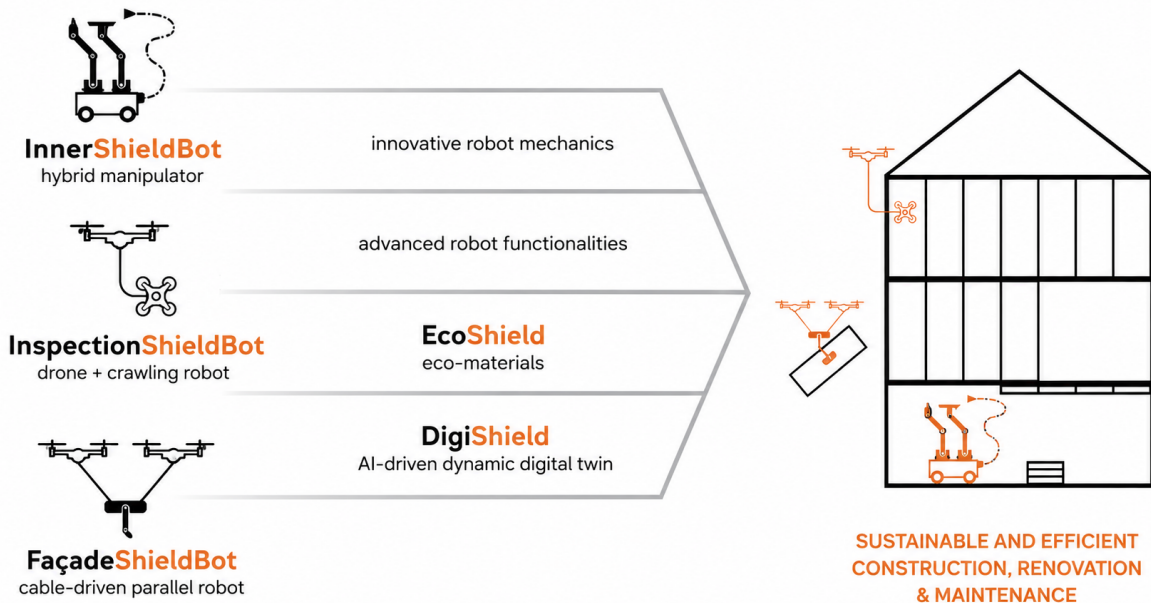


Figure 1.1: Robotic solutions developed by the ShieldBot project [1]

This thesis focuses on the robotic manipulation challenges inherent to the FaçadeShieldBot scenario. The system must generate sufficient force to manipulate the payload while

maintaining a stable pose, as the application requires transporting and accurately positioning a payload near a vertical surface. At the same time, it must operate across large façades without requiring complex or permanent infrastructure on the building.

The overall system employs a platform-mounted robotic arm to manipulate and position tools along the surface. However, the scope of this work is strictly centered on the aerial platform itself and its ability to maintain a controlled pose without relying on permanent building infrastructure.

Previous robotic developments have demonstrated the potential of cable-based systems for construction applications. For example, the Titanbot project investigates cable-driven parallel robotic (CDPR) systems capable of transporting loads over large areas and reducing the physical effort required from construction workers [2]. Such systems benefit from the mechanical simplicity and large workspace offered by cable-based actuation. Additionally, their actuators can be located away from the manipulated payload, which makes them particularly attractive for applications involving heavy loads. However, conventional configurations generally rely on fixed or ground-based cable attachment points, which can limit their flexibility when operating over complex or changing environments.

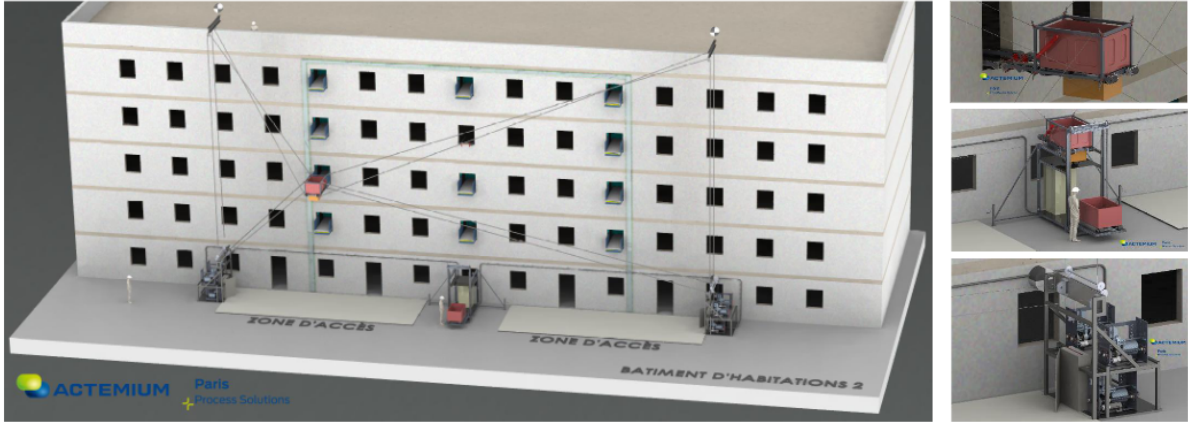


Figure 1.2: Solution proposed by TitanBot project [2]

Aerial robotic systems are a promising approach to access tight and difficult-to-reach areas while reducing the need for traditional scaffolding. Additionally, the use of cables introduces distance between the UAVs and the building, removing direct contact between the two. This is advantageous from a safety and operational perspective, as it reduces the risk of unintended collisions and the impact of the airflow generated by the rotors, allowing the system to safely come into contact with vertical surface [8].

Nonetheless, the position and orientation of the UAVs directly influence the forces and moments that can be generated through the cables. As a result, accurate positioning of the payload can become difficult, particularly when the system is required to perform precise manipulation close to a façade. These limits are especially critical in applications where the payload needs to be precisely positioned and then manipulated against a vertical surface.

The combination of aerial and ground-based actuation can improve the ability of the system to generate and control forces during interaction with the façade while retaining the flexibility of an aerial cable-towed system.

The resulting system, however, is characterized by a large set of design parameters that need to be selected at the design stage and remain fixed during the operation.

They strongly influence the workspace, wrench feasibility, controllability, robustness, and energy efficiency of the system. The main design degrees of freedom include:

- The number of aerial and ground vehicles (UAVs and UGVs), which determines the level of actuation redundancy and force distribution capability;
- The number of cables and their routing, which affect the achievable wrench set and the system's stability;
- The cable length actuation strategy, such as fixed-length or winch-actuated cables;
- The system architecture and graph rigidity, including centralized and decentralized control configurations.

As a result, architectural design cannot be isolated from control system development. A configuration that is mechanically feasible may nevertheless provide poor force distribution or positioning performance in the region of interest. Conversely, an appropriate choice of architecture and attachment locations can improve the controllability and robustness of the system without necessarily increasing its mechanical complexity.

The main objective of this thesis is to study the modelling, design, and control of a hybrid Aerial Cable-Towed System (ACTS) for payload manipulation. In particular, the thesis focuses on how the architecture and cable configuration influence the ability of the system to manipulate a payload and generate the required payload wrench. The work focuses on the selection of suitable cable routing and attachment configurations and on the development of a control approach based on the resulting system model. The proposed configurations are evaluated through simulation to assess their performance and identify the most suitable architecture for the considered application.

The thesis is organized as follows.

Chapter 2

Chapter 3

Chapter 4

Chapter 5

Chapter 6

Chapter 7

State of the Art

2.1 Cooperative Cable-Driven Aerial Systems

Several robotic architectures can be considered for the manipulation of a payload using multiple aerial vehicles. Among them, Cable-Driven Parallel Robots (CDPRs), Aerial Cable-Towed Systems (ACTSs), and Flying Parallel Robots (FPRs) are particularly relevant to the problem considered in this thesis. These architectures differ mainly in how the payload is connected to the actuators and consequently in their workspace, force-generation capabilities, and mechanical complexity.

2.1.1 Aerial Cable-Towed Systems

An Aerial Cable Towed Robot (ACTR) is a robotic system where the load is connected to multi-rotor UAVs through cables [3]. Other cables may be actuated also by non-aerial devices, such as actuators fixed to the ground or UGVs. In these systems, the payload motion is achieved by coordinating the cable tensions generated by the different actuators.

While standard ACTRs are limited in the directions and magnitudes of forces they can generate, the combination of mobile UAVs and fixed ground anchors enables the system to adapt its available wrench set to task requirements. This allows the platform to exert higher and more controllable interaction forces compared to configurations without a ground-based tension reference [9].

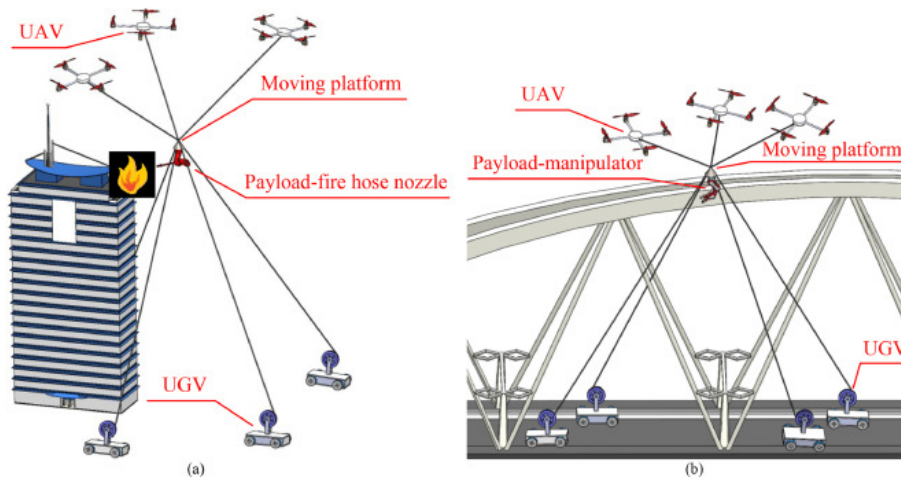


Figure 2.1: ACTRs with land-fixed winches for firefighting applications (a) and repair of a large bridge (b) [3]

2.1.2 Cable-Driven Parallel Robots

In conventional CDPRs, the end-effector is manipulated through flexible cables connected to fixed anchor points on the ground, and its motion is controlled by adjusting the cable lengths. Although CDPRs do not employ aerial robots, their analysis can be beneficial for making progress on ACTSs. As proposed by [8], ACTSs can be interpreted as reconfigurable CDPRs (RCDPRs), where fixed anchor points are replaced by mobile aerial platforms. For this reason, existing results on CDPR kinematics, dynamics, and control should not be ruled out a priori. A fundamental difference between CDPRs and ACTSs lies in the available tension space. In classical CDPR the tension's limits are fixed and do not depend on the robot's pose: the minimum tension is usually a small positive value to avoid slack, while the maximum tension is set by the motor torque. On the other hand, UAVs in ACTSs must always generate enough thrust to keep itself in the air and maintain its attitude, reducing the tension margin available for payload manipulation [10]. Therefore, CDPR findings can still be used for ACTSs, but they need to be adapted by introducing additional constraints due to the quadrotor actuation limits [8, 11].

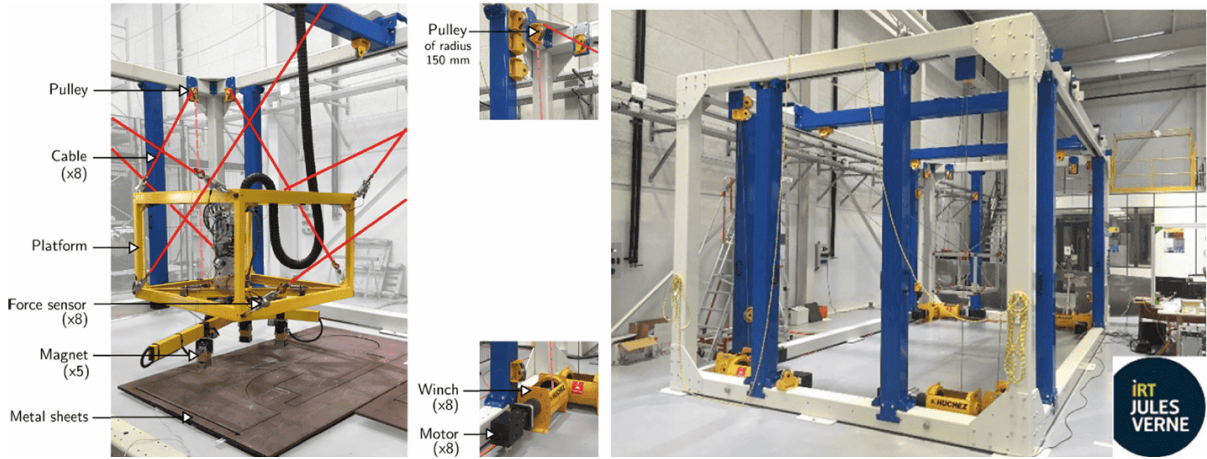


Figure 2.2: CDPR located at IRT Jules Verne [4, 5]

2.1.3 Flying Parallel Robots

Flying Parallel Robots (FPRs) changes from the previous two designs in that they connect the UAVs to the manipulated platform by rigid connections rather than cables, allowing both pushing and pull forces to be transmitted. Thus, the payload can be moved more freely since it has extra passive degrees of freedom inside its legs, also known as kinematic chains. These can be reorient without actuation, resulting into a platform that isn't over-constrained [12]. While this property can be helpful in interaction tasks, rigid links significantly increases the system's weight and the mechanical complexity [6]. Introducing UGVs in ACTSs as ground anchor points allows pulling forces, expanding the force applicable during interaction tasks. Lastly, even though cables cannot transmit compressive forces, the coordinated control of multiple cable tensions allows the system to counteract reaction forces arising during contact with vertical surfaces, achieving similar objectives without the need for rigid mechanical connections.

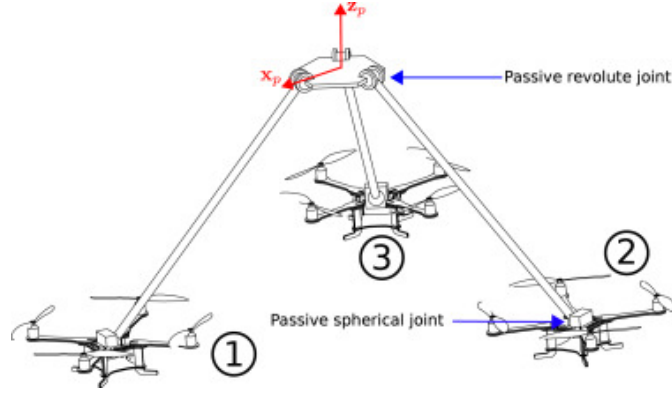


Figure 2.3: Kinematic scheme of the 3-DSR flying parallel robot [6]

2.2 Interaction with the Environment

Physical interaction is particularly challenging for aerial robotic systems because the motion of an aerial vehicle directly affects the forces it generates. Aerodynamic disturbances and modelling uncertainties further complicate the control of the system [12]. In a cable-suspended system, these effects are coupled: a change in the position of one UAV or of the payload modifies the cable directions and consequently the forces experienced by the other agents [13].

These challenges become particularly important when the payload operates close to a vertical surface. Accuracy is a critical requirement in such applications, and interaction with the environment introduces additional force constraints that are not present during free-space motion [9].

Near-façade operation can also be affected by aerodynamic phenomena. Ground and ceiling effects modify the UAV dynamics, while the propeller wash generated by one UAV can disturb other vehicles operating in close proximity [6, 13]. Furthermore, uncertainties in payload mass and inertia can affect the required thrust and lead to tracking errors or actuator saturation [8, 13].

Several forms of interaction have been considered for ACT systems, including unexpected collisions, planned contact, and active interaction with an external agent [14]. For the FaçadeShieldBot application, the relevant case is planned physical interaction with a vertical surface.

2.3 Control of Cable-Suspended UAV Systems

2.3.1 Centralized Control

Control architectures for cooperative aerial transportation can broadly be classified as centralized, distributed, or decentralized. In a centralized architecture, information about the UAVs, payload, and system configuration is available to a common controller. This allows the controller to coordinate the agents and explicitly account for the coupling between their motions.

A common approach is to model the ACTS as a continuously reconfigurable cable-driven parallel robot. In this framework, the controller can coordinate the payload motion, cable tensions, and UAV motion within a single control architecture [11, 8].

In [11], the design of a centralized trajectory tracking controller is proposed that explicitly accounts for both the kinematics and dynamics of the system. The control architecture is structured into three main layers:

- A task-space control loop that computes the desired wrench acting on the payload;
- A tension distribution algorithm that determines a feasible set of cable tensions realizing that desired wrench; and
- A joint-space control loop that converts the required cable forces into thrust and attitude commands for each quadrotor.

Differently, in distributed control systems, each agent computes its control action based on locally accessible information, which may be integrated with data resulting from the physical interaction with the shared payload. In this context, consensus algorithms allow individual robots to estimate global properties, such as formation parameters [15].

Lastly, in decentralized approaches, it is crucial that the ACTS maintains bearing rigidity in order to ensure that the system can reconstruct and preserve the formation geometry using only local measurements, avoiding uncontrolled motions and degenerate configurations.

The system considered here is assumed to operate under centralized control, for which the states and configuration of the relevant agents are available to a common controller.

2.3.2 Cable Tension and Force Control

Cable tension management is fundamental to the control of cable-driven systems because cables can only transmit tensile forces. The controller must therefore ensure that the tensions remain positive to prevent cable slackness and maintain the desired mechanical configuration.

In redundant cable-driven systems, several sets of cable tensions can generate the same net wrench on the payload. This redundancy can be exploited to satisfy additional constraints while maintaining the desired payload wrench. In particular, internal forces corresponding to the null space of the wrench mapping can be used to modify the tension distribution without changing the resulting payload wrench [11, 9].

For ACTSs, tension feasibility is further constrained by the UAVs' actuation limits. Each UAV must allocate part of its available thrust to compensate for its own weight and maintain its attitude, leaving only a limited portion of its actuation capability for payload manipulation [10]. A valid control solution must therefore consider both the desired payload wrench and the available actuation capabilities.

More recent approaches incorporate cable tension constraints directly into trajectory optimization, allowing future trajectories to be evaluated according to their feasibility with respect to cable tension and actuator limits [13]. Such approaches demonstrate the importance of considering cable forces explicitly when planning or controlling cooperative aerial systems.

ACTS Design and Modeling

3.1 System Architecture

To formulate a general methodology, it is important to adopt a parameterization of the ACTS. We consider an ACTS with n_q quadrotors, n_g ground vehicles, m cables, and a load with d degrees of freedom. The i -th quadrotor is connected to the load at point B_i through a cable of length l_i , whose other end is fixed to the vehicle at point A_i , for $i = 1, \dots, n_q$. Similarly, the j -th ground vehicle is connected to the load at point B_j via a cable of length l_j , attached to the vehicle at point A_j , for $j = 0, \dots, n_g$. To avoid ambiguity between aerial and ground actuators, alphabetical indeces may be used in the latter case to distinguish the two sets of vehicles [10].

We can also define the following systems of reference:

- $F_0(O, x_0, y_0, z_0)$ as the inertial reference world frame;
- $F_p(P, x_p, y_p, z_p)$ as the frame attached to the platform at its center of mass;
- $F_i(A_i, x_i, y_i, z_i)$ as the frame attached to the quadrotor at point A_i , with the z-axis normal to the plane of the rotors;
- $F_{C_i}(A_{C_i}, x_{C_i}, y_{C_i}, z_{C_i})$ as the frame attached to the quadrotor at its center of mass A_{C_i} with the x-axis pointing forward, the y-axis pointing left and the z-axis pointing upwards;
- $F_k(A_k, x_k, y_k, z_k)$ as the frame attached to the ground vehicle at point A_k , with the z-axis normal to the ground;

In particular, since the ground vehicles are considered fixed in pose, also their reference frame is inertial and the fixed in time transformation matrix T_k from the reference world frame to each ground vehicle is known.

In this thesis, the following assumptions are adopted:

- The cables are modeled as massless, non-extensible and perfectly straight [14, 10, 8];
- The cable attachment point coincides with the quadrotor's center of mass [6, 10, 12];
- There are no aerodynamic disturbances, such as the rotor wash [6, 12, 15];
- The flight is quasi-stationary and the aerodynamic friction and resistance can be neglected in the dynamic model [16, 10];

Lastly, the ground vehicles will be considered fixed anchoring points, as the ShieldBot project is still at its early stages.

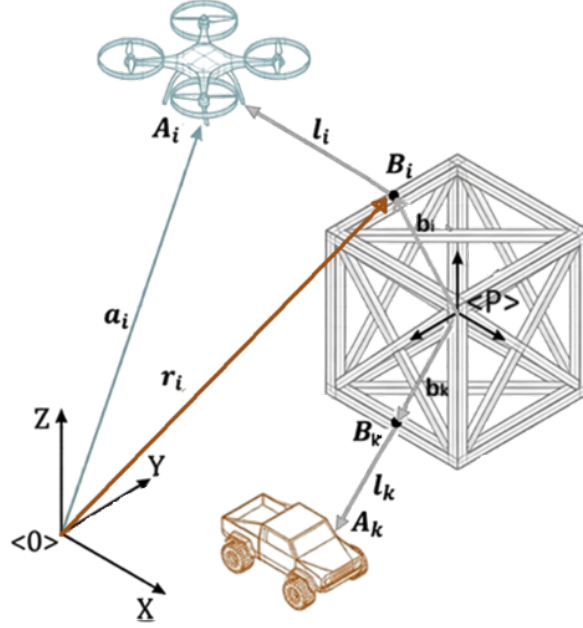


Figure 3.1: Graphical representation of the platform

3.2 Kinemato-static model

As talked about in Section 2.1.2, it is possible to model cable-suspended UAV systems as reconfigurable cable-driven parallel robots (RCDPRs), where the traditional fixed actuators are replaced by mobile UAVs, possibly integrated with land-fixed winches to balance interaction forces at high altitudes.

A kinemato-static model is a model that combines kinematics (motion and geometry) with statics (forces and equilibrium) to describe how a mechanical system moves and how forces are transmitted through it.

3.2.1 Kinematic model

Given the payload twist ${}^0\xi = [{}^0v_p \ {}^0\omega_p]^\top$ in the inertial reference frame $\langle 0 \rangle$, we can write the position and velocity of the attachment point B_i (resp. B_k) of the aerial vehicle (resp. ground) in $\langle 0 \rangle$.

$${}^0\mathbf{r}_i = {}^0\mathbf{p} + {}^0_P R^P \mathbf{b}_i \quad (3.1)$$

where $\mathbf{b}_i$ is the attachment point on payload.

$${}^0\dot{\mathbf{r}}_i = {}^0\mathbf{v}_p + {}^0\boldsymbol{\omega}_p \times ({}^0_P R^P \mathbf{b}_i) \quad (3.2)$$

For definition, the cable vector is $\mathbf{l}_i = \mathbf{a}_i - \mathbf{r}_i = A_i - B_i$ with $\mathbf{a}_i$ being the anchor position. Under a centralized controller, the positions of all UAV A_i and UGV A_k are known, which directly determine the anchor vector $\mathbf{a}_i$. Furthermore, the payload's position and orientation are assumed to be known. Together with the known locations of the attachment points relative to the payload, this information allows us to calculate the cable vectors $\mathbf{l}_i$.

The final form of cable vector variation is given by applying Equation 3.2 in its definition:

$$\dot{l}_i = \dot{\mathbf{a}}_i - \dot{\mathbf{r}}_i = \dot{\mathbf{a}}_i - \frac{d}{dt} (\mathbf{p} + {}_P R^P \mathbf{b}_i) = \dot{\mathbf{a}}_i - (\mathbf{v}_p + \boldsymbol{\omega}_p \times ({}_P R^P \mathbf{b}_i)) \quad (3.3)$$

Each $\dot{l}_i$ corresponds to the projection of the relative velocity of B_i along the cable direction

$$\begin{aligned} \dot{l}_i &= \mathbf{u}_i^\top (\dot{\mathbf{a}}_i - (\mathbf{v}_p + \boldsymbol{\omega}_p \times ({}_P R^P \mathbf{b}_i))) \\ &= \mathbf{u}_i^\top \dot{\mathbf{a}}_i - [\mathbf{u}_i^\top ({}_P R^P \mathbf{b}_i \times \mathbf{u}_i)^\top] \xi \\ &= J_{a,i} \dot{\mathbf{a}}_i - J_{p,i} \xi, \end{aligned} \quad (3.4)$$

This gives us the kinematic model that relates the variation of cable length vector $\boldsymbol{\rho}$ with the change in position of the anchors and the payload twist:

$$\dot{\boldsymbol{\rho}} = J_a \dot{\mathbf{a}} - J_p \xi = J_a \begin{bmatrix} \dot{\mathbf{a}}^{(a)} \\ \dot{\mathbf{a}}^{(g)} \end{bmatrix} - J_p \xi \quad (3.5)$$

Let $m = n_a + n_g$ be the total number of winches (or cables) and $\mathbf{u}_i = \mathbf{l}_i / \|\mathbf{l}_i\|$ the unit cable direction, then:

- $\dot{\boldsymbol{\rho}} = [\dot{l}_1 \ \dot{l}_2 \ \dots \ \dot{l}_m]^\top$ is the cable length rate (dimension $[m \times 1]$).
- J_a is the Jacobian relating the anchor velocities to the cable-length rates $[m \times 3m]$. In particular, each cable depends only on its anchor velocity.

$$J_a = \begin{bmatrix} u_1 & 0 & \dots & 0 \\ 0 & u_2 & \dots & 0 \\ \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \vdots \\ 0 & 0 & \dots & u_{n_a+n_g} \end{bmatrix}, \quad u_j = \frac{(a_j - r_j)}{\|a_j - r_j\|}. \quad (3.6)$$

- J_p is the Jacobian relating the payload twist to the cable-length $[m \times 6]$

$$J_p = \begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{u}_1^\top & ({}_P R^p \mathbf{b}_1 \times \mathbf{u}_1)^\top \\ \vdots & \vdots \\ \mathbf{u}_m^\top & ({}_P R^p \mathbf{b}_m \times \mathbf{u}_m)^\top \end{bmatrix} \quad (3.7)$$

Note 1. Equation 3.4 contains m equations in 6 unknown. I need at least six independent cable directions ($\text{rank}(J_p) = 6$).

The control allocation matrix maps the actuator inputs (cable tension vector) to the system (payload) wrench. For this definition $J_p^\top$ is the allocation matrix.

$$\mathbf{W}_p = J_p^\top \boldsymbol{\tau} \quad (3.8)$$

Let $\mathbf{W}_p^*$ being the desired payload wrench, the control allocation problem to solve is

$$J_p^\top \boldsymbol{\tau} = \mathbf{W}_p^*, \quad \text{s.t. } \tau_i > 0 \quad (3.9)$$

3.2.2 Static model

Let $\tau = [\tau_{uav}^\top, \tau_{ugv}^\top]^\top \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times 1}$ the cable tension vector, then

$$\begin{aligned} \underbrace{\tau^\top \dot{\rho}}_{\text{total cable power}} &= \underbrace{\tau^\top J_a \dot{a}}_{\text{UAVs and UGVs mechanical power}} - \underbrace{\tau^\top J_p \xi}_{\text{payload power}} \\ &= (J_a^\top \tau)^\top \dot{a} - (J_p^\top \tau)^\top \xi \\ &= F_a^\top \dot{a} - W_p^\top \xi \end{aligned} \quad (3.10)$$

Each cable i applies a force on the payload $F_{a,i}$ and an equal and opposite force on the UAV (resp. UGV). We can write balance equation on our elements:

Payload Balance

$$\underbrace{W_p}_{J_p^\top \tau} + \underbrace{W_g}_{\begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \\ -m_p g \\ 0 \\ 0 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}} + W_{contact} + \underbrace{W_{wind}}_{\text{let} = 0} = 0 \quad (3.11)$$

where since each cable produces a wrench on the payload, the contribution given by the i -th cable is:

$$\underbrace{w_{p,i}}_{6 \times 1} = \underbrace{J_{p,i}^\top}_{6 \times 1} \underbrace{\tau_i}_{1 \times 1} = [u_i^\top \quad ({}_P R^P b_i \times u_i)^\top]^\top \tau_i = \begin{bmatrix} \tau_i u_i \\ ({}_P R^P b_i \times \tau_i u_i) \end{bmatrix} \quad (3.12)$$

and $W_{contact} = 0$ when there is no contact with the environment.

UAV balance

$$-F_{a,i} + F_{prop,i} + \underbrace{F_{g,i}}_{\begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \\ -m_i g \end{bmatrix}} = 0 \quad (3.13)$$

with ${}^i F_{prop} = [0 \quad 0 \quad F_{prop,z,i}]^\top$ and $F_{a,i} = J_{a,i}^\top \tau_i = \tau_i u_i$.

UAVs must always generate sufficient thrust to maintain flight and ensure their own stability. As a result, only a portion of their available thrust can be allocated to payload manipulation, which reduces the effective force that can be transmitted through the cables.

UGV balance

$$-F_{a,j} + \underbrace{F_{ground,j}}_{\begin{bmatrix} F_{frict,x,j} \\ F_{frict,y,j} \\ F_{norm} \end{bmatrix}} + \underbrace{F_{g,j}}_{\begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \\ -m_j g \end{bmatrix}} = 0 \quad (3.14)$$

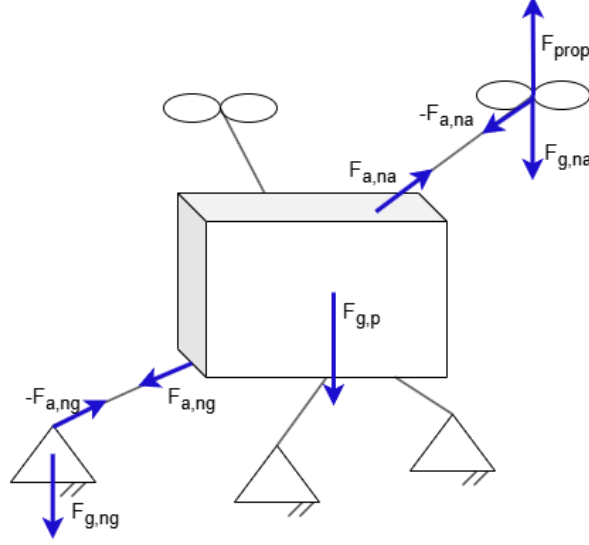


Figure 3.2: Forces acting on the ACTS

with $\|F_{frict}\| \leq \mu F_{norm}$ and $F_{norm} = m_j g - F_{a,z,j}$ and $F_{a,j}$ is obtained through Equation 3.15.

Similarly, UGVs are subject to ground interaction constraints. In particular, they must satisfy friction limits to remain stationary when no motion is commanded. This imposes bounds on the admissible cable forces, as excessive tension may cause slipping. By Newton's third law, the force the cable exerts on the drone $F_{a,i}$ (resp. on the UGV $F_{a,j}$) is equal and opposite to the force it exerts on the payload. Since u_i points from B_i toward A_i , the cable pulls the drone with

$$F_{a,i} = J_{a,i}^\top \tau_i = \tau_i u_i \quad (3.15)$$

As a consequence, the total cable force on the payload is:

$$F_p = - \sum_{i=1}^{n_a} F_{a,i} - \sum_{j=n_a+1}^{n_a+n_g} F_{a,j} \quad (3.16)$$

where the payload wrench is $W_p = [F_p \quad M_P]^\top$

3.2.3 Kinemato-static model

Writing Equation 3.11, 3.13 and 3.14 in term of τ , we obtain:

$$W_{sys} = \begin{bmatrix} W_p \\ F_a \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} J_p^\top \\ J_a^\top \end{bmatrix} \tau = G\tau = \begin{bmatrix} -W_g - W_{contact} - W_{wind} \\ F_{prop} + F_{ground} + F_g \end{bmatrix} \quad (3.17)$$

where $F_{prop,j} = 0$ for the UGVs and $F_{ground,i} = 0$ for the UAVs. Then W_{sys} is $(6+3m) \times 1$ and

$$G\tau + \begin{bmatrix} W_g + W_{contact} + W_{wind} \\ -F_{prop} - F_{ground} - F_g \end{bmatrix} = 0 \quad (3.18)$$

3.3 Architecture Design

The configuration of a cooperative aerial transportation system (ACTS) has a direct influence on its workspace, force-generation capabilities, controllability, and energy consumption. For a given payload pose, multiple equilibrium configurations may exist, corresponding to different distributions of internal cable forces that do not modify the resulting net wrench acting on the payload. Although these configurations satisfy the same static equilibrium conditions, they can require significantly different UAV positions and cable tensions, leading to different energy consumption and robustness properties [17].

Consequently, the architecture of the ACTS must be selected according to the requirements of the intended application. In this thesis, the architecture design is described through a set of configurable parameters that determine the number and arrangement of aerial and ground actuators, the cable attachment points, and the cable routing. These parameters define the architecture search space explored in the remainder of this chapter.

The ACTS consists of at least one UAV, required as the payload needs to be lifted from the ground, and one UGV, included for safety and operational constraints. To fully control the payload in space, we need at least six cables.

3.3.1 Design Variables

As it will be discussed better in detail later, in this work we suppose working with a fixed number of UAVs and ground cables. On the other hand, the main design variables considered are:

- the payload attachment point locations;
- the ground anchor locations; and
- the cable routing between the ground actuators and the payload.

Aerial Actuators

The configuration of the UAV connections is crucial as it directly affects how forces are applied to the payload. UAVs are responsible for generating the lifting force required to lift the payload. Consequently, the number of UAVs depends strongly on the payload mass. However, increasing the number of UAVs leads to higher power consumption and greater system complexity. So, adding more UAVs does not necessarily improve performance. Additionally, each UAV can be connected to the payload using either a single cable or multiple cables. The choice of configuration affects controllability, wrench feasibility, robustness, and energy efficiency, and should be evaluated accordingly. A practical compromise is to use three UAVs connected to the payload at distinct attachment points, providing a balance between the metrics just mentioned (Figure 3.3).

The main alternatives considered in this work are illustrated in Figure 3.3.

Ground Actuators and Anchors

In contrast, UGVs do not contribute to lifting the payload, meaning the same stability arguments do not apply. If we treat the UGVs as fixed anchor points, connecting a single UGV to multiple hook points on the payload simplifies to a standard fixed-anchor

scenario. Because each actuator operates independently, this configuration adds no extra mathematical complexity. However, if the UGVs are actively moving, multi-cable connections require precise winch coordination to ensure all cables remain taut at all times. In Figure 3.4, possible payload hook attachment can be found.

The number and spatial distribution of these anchors affect the directions of the corresponding cable forces and therefore the wrench that can be generated at the payload. Different anchor layouts can consequently lead to different force and moment capabilities.

Payload Attachment Points

The locations of the cable attachment points on the payload directly affect the moments generated by cable tensions. Attachment points that are more widely separated can provide larger moment arms, whereas closely spaced attachment points result in different wrench and conditioning properties.

The attachment geometry therefore influences:

- the achievable payload wrench;
- the ability to generate moments;
- the conditioning of the wrench mapping; and
- the feasibility of maintaining positive cable tensions.

The attachment points are therefore treated as design variables in the architecture selection process.

Ground Anchor Placement and Cable Routing

The positions of the ground anchors determine the directions of the ground cables for a given payload pose. Their arrangement consequently affects both the achievable wrench and the distribution of cable tensions.

In addition to anchor placement, the routing of the cables between the ground anchors and the payload attachment points is considered as a design variable. Candidate routings include crossed and uncrossed arrangements, as well as adjacent and diagonal connections. These different routings can produce different cable directions and therefore different force-generation capabilities.

integrate this

The design variables described above define the architecture search space considered in this thesis. Rather than evaluating every possible combination, a set of candidate configurations is selected to represent the main architectural alternatives.

For the aerial part of the system, the candidates differ in the number of UAVs and in the number and arrangement of cables connecting the UAVs to the payload. For the ground part, different anchor distributions and cable routings are considered. Finally, the payload attachment geometry is varied to investigate its influence on the resulting wrench capabilities.

The candidate architectures are subsequently evaluated using the performance indices introduced in Section 3.3.2. The selected architecture is then used for the detailed kinemato-static modeling and control development presented in the following sections.

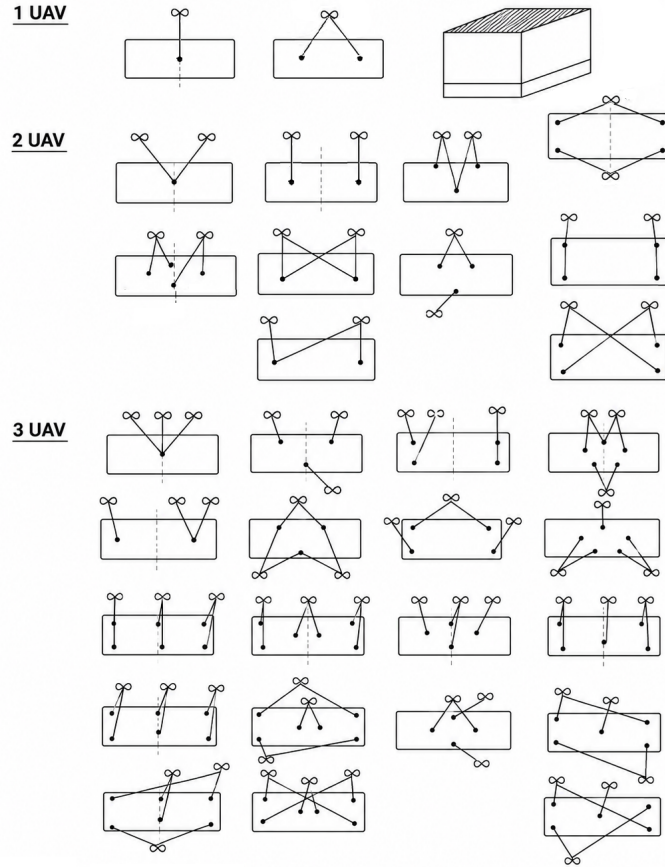


Figure 3.3: Possible UAVs connection to the payload

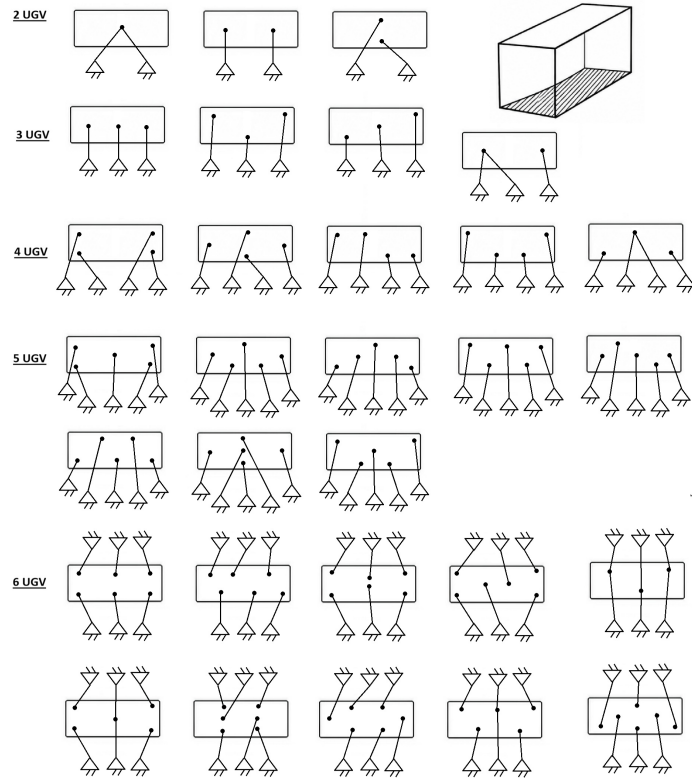


Figure 3.4: Possible UGVs connection to the payload

3.3.2 Performance Metrics

In the context of the ShieldBot project, we are working with two questions:

1. Which attachment geometry gives the best ability to generate the required payload wrench over the entire mission workspace?
2. Given the chosen architecture, where should the actuators (UAVs and anchor points in the ground) be positioned and what cable lengths should be used during operation?

In both cases, we need an objective measurement that guides us in the selection. Every configuration to be eligible needs to satisfy feasibility metrics first, such as [18]:

- Wrench closure conditions (WCC), which guarantees that the payload is fully constrained and arbitrary wrenches can be generated. Mathematically: $\text{rank}(J_p) = 6$ and positive tensions exist.
- Wrench Feasible Condition (WFC), which checks whether tensions remain in the feasible bound $0 \leq \tau_{\min} \leq \tau \leq \tau_{\max}$, included UAV thrust limits, cable strength limits and UGV friction limits in a future where the ground anchor point will be movable.
- Interference-Free Condition (IFC), ensuring that there is no cable rubbing and no collision with payload edges. Mathematically:

$$\begin{aligned} d_{ij} &\geq d_{\text{safe}}, \quad \text{where } d_{ij} = \text{dist}(\text{cable } i, \text{cable } j) & \forall i, j \\ d_i &\geq d_{\text{safe}}, \quad \text{where } d_i = \min_{s \in [0,1]} (\text{dist}(r_i + s(a_i - r_i), P)) & \forall i \end{aligned} \quad (3.19)$$

where P is the payload geometry and d_{safe} is a clearance threshold.

check this

However, assuming that all cable attachment points are on the same face of the payload, the only feasible interference between the latter and one of the cables is a near-tangent cable that touches that face. This requirement will be assumed to always be met, as this study places the ACTS in a scenario where this corner case is rarely encountered.

After passing the feasibility filters, we need a way to assign a score to each hook configuration.

Capacity margin or minimum degree of constraint satisfaction

The capacity margin is a robustness index that is used to analyze the degree of feasibility of a configuration. It is defined as the shortest signed distance from the task wrench to the boundary of the available wrench set (AWS). Mathematically, it is the minimum of the distances of each one of the n vertex $w_{e,j}$ to each one of the p facet $(\mathbf{a}_l, b_l)$ of the AWS.

$$\gamma = \min_{j=1 \div n} \min_{l=1 \div p} \gamma_{j,l}, \quad \text{where } \gamma_{j,l} = \frac{b_l - w_{e,j}^\top \mathbf{a}_l}{\|\mathbf{a}_l\|_2} \quad (3.20)$$

where $\mathbf{a}_l$ is the normal vector to the l -th facet and b_l is its offset [19].

Worst-Case Capacity Margin

Additionally, we can define the worst-case capacity margin as how far the system remains from actuator saturation in the most demanding operating condition. Mathematically:

$$\zeta = \min \left(1 - \max_i \frac{\tau_i}{\tau_{i,max}} \right) \quad (3.21)$$

For each drone, the maximum available cable tension $t_{i,max}$ is based on its maximum thrust $f_{i,max}$ and its current orientation relative to the cable [10]

$$t_{i,max} = m_i \mathbf{u}_i^T (\mathbf{g} - \ddot{\mathbf{x}}_i) + \sqrt{f_{i,max}^2 + m_i^2 \left((\mathbf{u}_i^T (\ddot{\mathbf{x}}_i - \mathbf{g}))^2 - \ddot{\mathbf{x}}_i^T \ddot{\mathbf{x}}_i - \mathbf{g}^T \mathbf{g} \right)} \quad (3.22)$$

Considering only quasi-static motion, this can be reduced to the following, where $u_{iz} = [0 \ 0 \ 1] \mathbf{u}_i$ and $g = [0 \ 0 \ 1] \mathbf{g}$.

$$t_{i,max} = m_i g u_{iz} + \sqrt{f_{i,max}^2 + m_i^2 g^2 (u_{iz}^2 - 1)} \quad (3.23)$$

adapt, it is usufull here

According to [8], the capacity margin index can be used as a measure of controllability for an ACTS, as it accurately estimates the feasibility region of the ACTS for quasi-static trajectories. The feasibility region is the set of all poses and geometric configurations in which the system can physically balance a required task wrench, such as gravity or external interaction forces, while satisfying the quadrotor's actuation limits and the physical constraints of the cables. In practice, the capacity margin quantifies how far the current operating point is from the boundary of what the system can physically achieve. These definitions lead to the following corollary:

The capacity margin can be used to determine the minimum set of external wrenches on the platform that the ACTS can compensate for solely with modifications to the attitude of the quadrotor [10].

Radius of Available Wrench (rAw)

The radius of the available wrench (rAW) is the maximum magnitude of force that the system can generate uniformly in all directions while remaining within admissible tension limits [9]. Its optimization helps identify arrangements that simultaneously maximize force robustness, geometric and collision-avoidance constraints, resulting into an enlargement of the static workspace [9].

$$rAW = \min_i \left(\min \left(\frac{|d_{pi}|}{\|\mathbf{n}_{null,i}\|}, \frac{|d_{qi}|}{\|\mathbf{n}_{null,i}\|} \right) \right) \quad (3.24)$$

being $u_{null,i} = \text{null}(M_i)$ with M_i containing combinations of linearly independent cable unit vectors and d_{pi} and d_{qi} defined as:

$$\begin{aligned} d_{pi} &= \sum_{j \in I^+} \tau_{max} u_{null,i}^T u_j + \sum_{j \in I^-} \tau_{min} u_{null,i}^T u_j - m |u_{null,i}^T \mathbf{g}| \\ d_{qi} &= - \sum_{j \in I^-} \tau_{max} u_{null,i}^T u_j - \sum_{j \in I^+} \tau_{min} u_{null,i}^T u_j - m |u_{null,i}^T \mathbf{g}| \end{aligned} \quad (3.25)$$

However, since [9] consider the case of a point-mass payload, it does not take in consideration the torques, we may compute separately rAW_{force} and rAW_{moment} , the maximum pure force (resp. torque) the platform can exert in any direction while generating zero net moment (resp. linear force).

Look at this

The radius of the available wrench (rAW) is the maximum magnitude of force that the system can generate uniformly in all directions while remaining within admissible tension limits. This metric is useful to quantify the robustness of a given configuration: the larger it is, the more robust it is to reject disturbances. As a consequence, the optimal arrangement of UAVs for a given payload pose is the configuration that maximizes rAW [9]. By optimizing this force-based index over the set of admissible UAV configurations, it is possible to identify arrangements that simultaneously maximize force robustness while satisfying geometric and collision-avoidance constraints. This optimization process directly leads to an enlargement of the Static Workspace (SW), highlighting the intrinsic coupling between wrench feasibility and workspace size.

The boundary of the static workspace SW corresponds to configurations where the rAW reduces to zero, indicating a loss of force feasibility in at least one direction. The static workspace is strongly influenced by UAV placement, cable routing, and thrust capabilities since UAV cable tension depend heavily on the geometry of the system. While multiple UAV arrangements may satisfy kinematic constraints for a given payload pose, only a subset of these configurations provide adequate force feasibility and robustness. Consequently, force-based workspace analysis plays a central role in system design and configuration optimization [9].

Conditioning index

The conditioning index measures how uniformly the system can generate forces and moments in different directions. Mathematically:

$$\nu = \frac{\sigma_{\min}(J_p)}{\sigma_{\max}(J_p)} \in [0, 1] \quad (3.26)$$

$\sigma_{\min}$ and $\sigma_{\max}$ are the minimum and maximum singular values of the Jacobian matrix, obtained via Singular Value Decomposition (SVD) [15]. A small conditioning number indicates a well-conditioned system, far-away from singular configuration.

Manipulability

The manipulability index, defined as $w = \sqrt{\det(J_p J_p^T)}$, measures the volume of the wrench ellipsoid. A value close to 0 means that the system hit a kinematic singularity, while large value means a large overall wrench generation capability.

3.3.3 Selection Strategy

update it with what we are actually using

Say that this is an option but then just announced which one we used, but it will be talked better in the next chapter

Once the feasibility constraints are satisfied, we may want to proceed either by

$$N = w_1 \hat{\gamma} + w_2 r \hat{A} w + w_3 \hat{\zeta} \quad (3.27)$$

where all the metrics are scaled to $[0, 1]$, or either choosing the solution that maximizes the radius of available wrench between all the solutions that satisfy $\gamma > \gamma_{\min}$ and using the worst-case capacity margin as a tie breaker.

Our solution will finally be:

$$U^* = \arg \max_U (N(U)) \quad (3.28)$$

3.3.4 Selected architecture

We are interested in working with an over-actuated system. Therefore, we will start using six cables for fully control the payload pose and three drones acting as an anti-gravitational force. A schematic is shown in Figure 3.5.

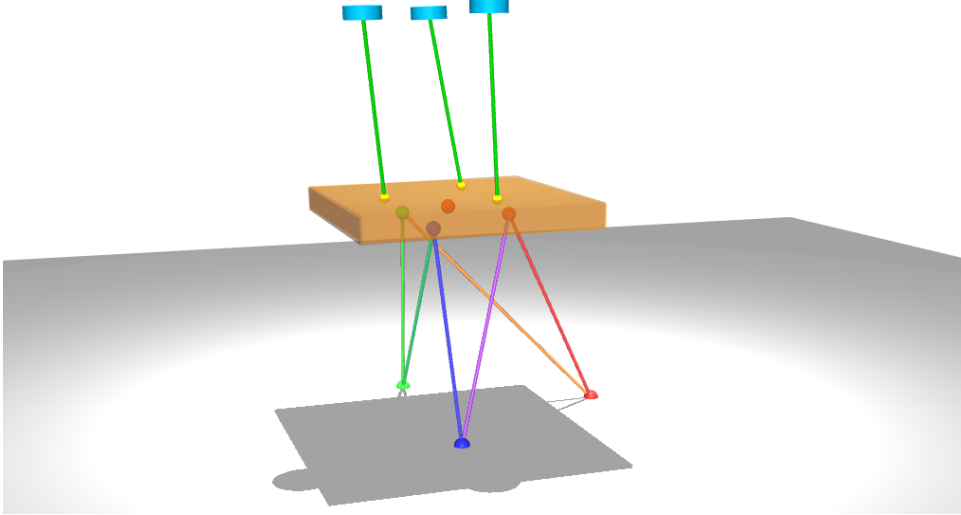


Figure 3.5: Over actuated ACTS with 6 ground cables and 3 UAVs

Control of the ACTS

4.1 Force control with a point-mass payload

Before going into details on the full consideration, let's analyze some simpler configurations.

4.1.1 Case: one drone connected to the ground through a cable

The goal is to design the drone force F_{prop} such as that the ground tension is controlled. Since only a tension in the cable direction is imposable, an arbitrary force f^* at the ground anchor can be achieved only by moving the drone, changing the cable direction u . Called a the drone's position and b the attachment point to the ground:

$$u = \frac{a - b}{\|a - b\|} \quad (4.1)$$

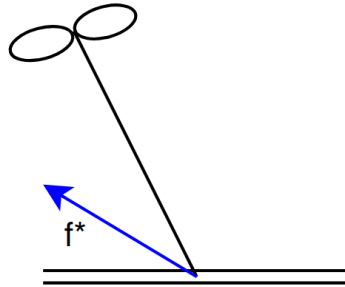


Figure 4.1: One drone system connected to the ground through a cable

Option 1

Defined the desired cable tension τ^* and the desired cable direction u^* as:

$$\tau^* = \|f^*\| \quad (4.2) \quad u^* = \frac{f^*}{\|f^*\|} \quad (4.3)$$

the ground tension is obtained using the geometric constraint which relates the anchor point to the drone position:

$$a^* = b + l u^* \quad (4.4)$$

where l is the cable length. Equation 4.4 is then used as a reference to compute the propeller force.

$$F_{prop} = m_i g e_3 + K_p(a^* - a) + K_d(\dot{a}^* - \dot{a}) + \tau^* u \quad (4.5)$$

Option 2

Given the drone Newton's Second Law described in Equation 3.13, we are able to estimate the cable force $\hat{f} = F_{a,i}^{est}$

$$m_i \ddot{a}_i = F_{prop,i} - \hat{f} + F_{g,i} \quad \rightarrow \quad \hat{f} = F_{prop,i} + F_{g,i} - m_i \ddot{a}_i \quad (4.6)$$

where all the forces are in the world frame and $\ddot{a}_i$ is the drone linear acceleration. Using Equation 3.13, we would like to apply a propulsion force equal to

$$F_{prop,i}^* = f^* - F_{g,i} \quad (4.7)$$

Finally, the closed loop equation is:

$$F_{prop,i} = F_{prop,i}^* + K_p e + K_d \dot{e}, \quad \text{with } e = f^* - \hat{f} \quad (4.8)$$

The result is given to the attitude controller, which aligns the body z-axis with the commanded thrust vector.

4.1.2 Case: payload connected to the ground and a drone

In this case, we are working with the simplified case of an ACTS composed by a drone, a ground anchor and a point-mass payload. Called with subscript 1 the cable that connects the payload to the drone and with 2 the one that connects it to the ground, for definition the vector u_i , $i = 1 \div n$ is given by

$$u_i = \frac{a_i - p}{\|a_i - p\|} \quad (4.9)$$

being a_i and p respectively the actuator and the payload position.

Payload position control

The goal is to design $F_{prop,1}$ such that the payload reaches a desired position ($p \rightarrow p^*$), which is reachable for the length of the cable.

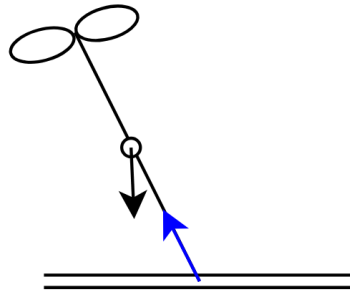


Figure 4.2: Simplified ACTS with one drone and one ground anchor

The payload dynamics is given by:

$$\begin{aligned}
m_p \ddot{p} &= \tau_1 u_1 + \tau_2 u_2 - m_p g e_3 \\
&= F_{a,1} + F_{a,2} + F_g \quad \rightarrow \quad F_p = m_p(\ddot{p} + g e_3) \\
&= F_p + F_g
\end{aligned} \tag{4.10}$$

The desired payload force is defined using an impedance controller:

$$F_p^* = m_p(\ddot{p}^* + g e_3) + K_p(p^* - p) + K_d(\dot{p}^* - \dot{p}) \tag{4.11}$$

with $\dot{p}^* = 0$ and $\ddot{p} = 0$ as we required the payload to maintain the position once it is reached. The remaining force to be generated by cable 1 is:

$$F_{a,1}^* = F_p^* - F_{a,2} \tag{4.12}$$

where $F_{a,2} = \tau_2 u_2$. This brings us back to the situation in Section 4.1.1, where $F_{a,1}$ is f^* .

Tension and orientation control

The goal can also be design $F_{prop,1}$ such that an arbitrary force f^* on the ground can be applied ($F_2 \rightarrow f^*$). In other words, $u_2 \rightarrow u_2^*$ and $\tau_2 \rightarrow \tau_2^*$. This case can be interesting to study as in a redundancy system situation, it may be helpful to add additional constraint in one of the cables. The only difference from the previous case is that the desired position for the payload p^* is not an input anymore, but obtained such that the 2nd cable is aligned along the desired direction given by f^* (Equation 4.2 and 4.3). Then:

$$p^* = a_2 - l_2 u_2^* \tag{4.13}$$

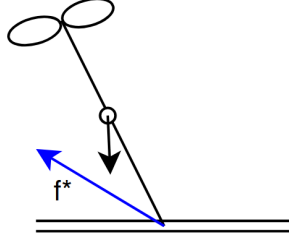


Figure 4.3: Tension directed arbitrary

4.1.3 Case: payload connected to the ground through two cables

The ACTS consists of a point-mass payload connected to the ground through two cables and to an UAV. The enumeration is shown in Figure 4.4.

Payload position control

If the input is the desired payload position p^* , we find ourselves in three situations:

1. p^* lies precisely on the intersecting boundary arcs dictated by the maximum lengths of the ground cables;

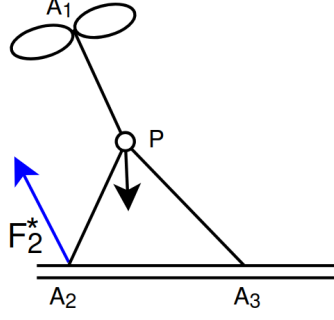


Figure 4.4: Payload connected through two cable to the ground

2. p^* is out of reach;
3. p^* is inside the triangle A_1A_3P , resulting into slack cables

In the first case, p^* is used to compute the desired payload force F_p^* (Equation 4.11). Using the simplified payload balance equation related to the forces acting on the payload (Equation 3.16), we obtain the following.

$$F_{a,1}^* = F_p^* - \sum_{i=2}^n F_{a,i} \quad (4.14)$$

which brings us back to the previous case.

Because the payload is physically constrained at a boundary where both ground cables are stretched straight, any movement or external disturbance is perfectly resisted by the tension of the cables.

In the second case, since the ground cables physically block the payload from reaching p^* , a steady error $e = (p^* - p) \neq 0$ builds up. The actual tension will be directly proportional to the control gains and the distance of the unreachable input:

$$\sum F_{virtual} \propto (p^* - p_{geom}) \implies \sum F_{virtual} = K(p^* - p_{geom}) \quad (4.15)$$

where p_{geom} is the closest reachable point that lies on the workspace boundary. In this case, we may impose a controlled tension on the ground cables directed along $(p^* - p_{geom})$ to ensure the drone continues to pull toward the desired target:

$$F_{a,1}^* = F_p^* - \sum_{i=2}^n F_{a,i} + F_{virtual} \quad (4.16)$$

In the last case, the distance from the anchors to the payload is less than the cable length, resulting into slack cables as the latter cannot push. Mathematically $\tau_2 = 0$ and/or $\tau_3 = 0$. Then, $F_{a,1}^* = F_p^*$

Desired tension in the cable on the ground

The desired variable to control is the tension of one of the cables $F_{a,2} \rightarrow f^*$.

$$F_{a,1}^* = F_p^* - f^* - F_{a,2} \quad (4.17)$$

where $F_p = m_p(\ddot{p} + ge_3)$ and $F_{a,2} = \tau_2 u_2$.

Desired tension difference between the cables on the ground

The desired variable to control a linear combination of the two $F_{a,2} + \alpha F_{a,3} \rightarrow f^*$.

$$\begin{aligned} F_{a,1} = F_p - F_{a,2} - F_{a,3} & \implies F_{a,1}^* = F_p - (f^* - \alpha F_{a,3}^* + F_{a,3}^*) \\ & = F_p - f^* - (1 - \alpha)F_{a,3} \end{aligned} \quad (4.18)$$

For the specific case where $F_{a,2} - F_{a,3} \rightarrow f^*$:

$$F_{a,1}^* = F_p - f^* - 2F_{a,3}^* = F_p - f'^* \quad (4.19)$$

4.2 Extension to the Complete ACTS Architecture

At high level, the architecture that enables the system to reach the goal is shown in Figure 4.5.

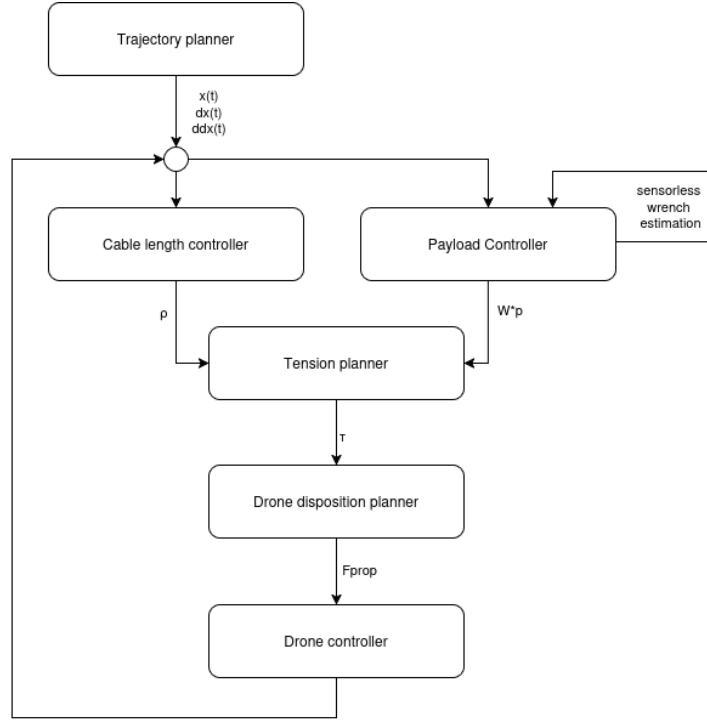


Figure 4.5: High level control scheme

Trajectory planner

The trajectory planner is able to compute the payload trajectory $x(t)$ and its velocity $\dot{x}(t)$ and acceleration $\ddot{x}(t)$ given the system's goal, such as:

1. Make the payload fly;
2. Bring the payload at the right height and orientation;
3. Approach the façade.

and/or the initial and final position of the payload.

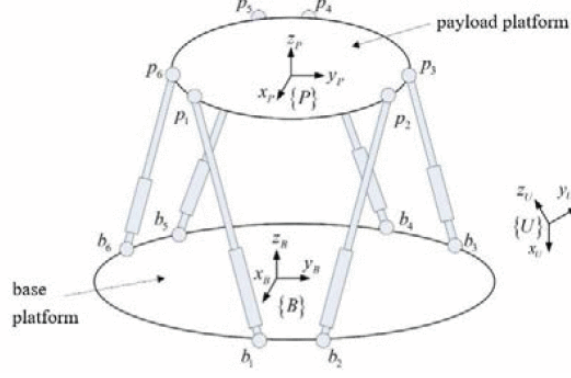


Figure 4.6: Gough Stewart schematics [7]

Payload Controller

Then, the desired payload wrench W_p^* is computed for each point in the trajectory based on the previous state of the system. The desired payload wrench is computed from a geometric PD controller. The translational component is given by

$$F_p^* = m_p g + K_p(p^* - p) + K_d(\dot{p}^* - \dot{p}), \quad (4.20)$$

where p^* and p denote the desired and current payload positions, respectively.

For the rotational dynamics, the controller follows the geometric formulation on $SE(3)$ [20]. The attitude error and angular velocity error are defined as

$$\begin{aligned} e_R &= \frac{1}{2} (R_d^T R - R^T R_d)^\vee \\ e_\Omega &= \Omega - R^T R_d \Omega_d. \end{aligned} \quad (4.21)$$

where $(\cdot)^\vee$ denotes the inverse of the skew-symmetric (hat) operator.

Since the controller performs setpoint regulation, $\Omega_d = \mathbf{0}$, yielding $e_\Omega = \Omega$.

The desired control moment in the world frame is then

$$M_p^* = R(-K_R e_R + K_\Omega e_\Omega) \quad (4.22)$$

and the desired payload wrench becomes

$$W_p^* = \begin{bmatrix} F_p^* \\ M_p^* \end{bmatrix}. \quad (4.23)$$

Cable length controller (winch level control)

When transitioning from a desired payload pose to the next along the planned trajectory, the operational priority is given to the ground actuators, as they can be controllable with significantly higher precision than UAVs.

As the starting ACTS configuration consists of six ground cables, the ground sub-system can be modeled as a Gough-Stewart parallel platform (Figure 4.6), where the required positive cable tensions are guaranteed by the drones.

Given the desired payload position p^* and the rotation matrix ${}^0_p R^*$ that defines the desired orientation of the payload relative to the fixed world frame, the desired i -th ground

cable vector ${}^0\mathbf{l}_i^*$ is geometrically defined as:

$${}^0\mathbf{l}_i^* = {}^0\mathbf{a}_i - {}^0\mathbf{r}_i = {}^0\mathbf{a}_i - ({}^0\mathbf{p}^* + {}^0R^* {}^p\mathbf{b}_i) \quad (4.24)$$

At the end trusted pulley control, talk about it

The target leg length is $\rho_i^* = \|l_i^*\|$. To ensure precise tracking of the ground cable lengths, we can either implement a PD controller at the winch level, where the velocity command $\dot{\rho}_i$ is given by:

$$\dot{\rho}_i = \dot{\rho}_i^* + K_i(\rho_i^* - \rho_i) + K_p(\dot{\rho}_i^* - \dot{\rho}_i) \quad (4.25)$$

Under the assumption of stationary winches ($\dot{a} = 0$), $\dot{\rho}_{ground}^* = -J_{p,ground}\xi^*$ (Equation 3.5), where ξ^* is the desired payload twist and $J_{p,ground} \in \mathbb{R}^{6 \times 6}$ is the Jacobian matrix mapping the payload twist to the ground cable length variation. In simulation, we implement a control directly on the cable length:

$$l_i = l_i^* + K_p(l_i^* - l_i) + K_d(\dot{l}_i^* - \dot{l}_i) \quad (4.26)$$

Tension planner

The tension planner is the layer responsible for guaranteeing that every cable stays taut throughout the motion. In fact, when working with ACTS, a payload wrench configuration is statically admissible if and only if there exists a set of strictly positive cable tensions ($\tau_i \geq \tau_{min} > 0$) that balance the target operational wrench. This is due to the fact that cables can only pull and not push. Mathematically, this layout optimization is formulated as:

$$\begin{aligned} \min_{p_a} \quad & \sum_{i=1}^{n_a} \|F_{prop}(p_{a,i}, \tau_{optimal,i})\|^2 + K \|J_p \tau_{optimal} - W_p^*\|^2 \\ \text{subj. to} \quad & x_i^2 + y_i^2 + z_i^2 = l_i^2 \quad \forall i \in [1, n_a] \\ & \rho_{WCC}(\mathcal{U}) \leq 0 \\ & \rho_{IFC}(\mathcal{U}) \leq 0 \end{aligned} \quad (4.27)$$

which is a Nonlinear optimization Problem (NLP) due to the Euclidean distance constraints.

This objective function aims to minimize the propulsion force of the drones while satisfying the wrench equilibrium equations on the payload. The parameter K acts as a penalty weight that prioritizes the tracking performance over energy efficiency; setting a high value (e.g., $K = 1000$), heavily penalizes any mismatch between the generated wrench and the commanded target wrench W_p^* .

For whatever positions p_a , the cable tensions τ are determined by a second inner loop

$$\begin{aligned} \tau_{optimal} = \arg \min_{\tau} \quad & \frac{1}{2} \tau^\top H \tau \\ \text{subj. to} \quad & J_p^\top(\mathbf{u}) \tau = W_p^* \\ & \tau_{min,i} \leq \tau_i \leq \tau_{max,i} \quad \forall i \in [1, n_a + n_g] \end{aligned} \quad (4.28)$$

The lower bound $\tau_{min,i} > 0$ in the wrench feasible condition is what enforces the taut-cable requirement.

As the winch-level control drives $\rho \rightarrow \rho^*$, tracking the payload's motion toward its target pose, and $\mathbf{u} \rightarrow \mathbf{u}^*$, the achievable wrench set used by the tension planner is itself changing over the trajectory, since it depends on $\mathbf{u}$. As a consequence, $\mathbf{W}_p^*$ may be reachable at the target configuration but momentarily unreachable at the actual configuration, with all tensions kept strictly positive. When this occurs, Equation 4.28 should relax the equality constraint $\mathbf{J}_p^\top(\mathbf{u})\tau = \mathbf{W}_p^*$ to a least-squares objective, while keeping $\tau_{min,i} > 0$ as a hard constraint.

$$\begin{aligned} \tau_{optimal} = \arg \min_{\tau} & \left(\frac{1}{2} \tau^\top H \tau + \gamma \|J_p^\top(\mathbf{u})\tau - W_p^*\|^2 \right) \\ \text{subj. to } & \tau_{min,i} \leq \tau_i \leq t_{max,i} \quad \forall i \in [1, n_a + n_g] \end{aligned} \quad (4.29)$$

This guarantees that the tension planner always returns a taut solution, one that approximates the desired wrench as closely as the actual geometry allows, rather than returning no solution at all during the transient.

For the initial stage of development, this general QP is replaced by a simplified strategy: every cable tension is fixed at the minimum admissible value,

$$\|\tau_i^*\| = \tau_{min}, \quad \forall i \in [1, n_a + n_g]. \quad (4.30)$$

Drone disposition planner

Once the tension planner computes the scalar target tension magnitudes, the drones must dynamically adjust their orientation and propeller thrusts to impose these forces.

From the static equilibrium balance (Equation 3.13) the required propeller thrust vector is given by:

$$\mathbf{F}_{prop,i} = \mathbf{F}_{a,i} - \mathbf{F}_{g,i} = \mathbf{J}_{a,i}^\top \tau_i + m_i \mathbf{g} = T_i {}^0\mathbf{R}_i \mathbf{e}_3, \quad T_i = \|\mathbf{F}_{prop,i}\| \quad (4.31)$$

which is then handed to the attitude controller, responsible for aligning the body z -axis with the commanded thrust vector.

Simulation Environment and Experimental Setup

5.1 Motivation for simulation environments

Why simulation is required Advantages and limitations Role of simulation in controller validation Simulation environment to avoid write dynamic equations

5.2 Simulator selection

5.2.1 Gazebo environment

Features Physics engine Advantages/disadvantages

5.2.2 MuJoCo environment

Features Physics engine Advantages/disadvantages

5.3 Software architecture (UML)

5.4 Simulation setup

5.5 Simulation methodology and evaluation framework

The objective of this chapter is to evaluate how the architectural design of an ACTS influences its ability to accurately and robustly manipulate a payload. The focus is on how different cable routing strategies, UAV attachment configurations, and ground hook placements influence the overall system performance.

In fact, a configuration is considered successful if the desired payload is reached with sufficiently small position and orientation errors, all cables remain under positive tension throughout the maneuver, and the payload converges to an equilibrium without persistent oscillations.

In this chapter we will answer questions like "Which configuration gives the best payload control performance according to the theoretical indices?" and "Which configuration would I actually choose for the robot?"

The geometric and static performance indices provided in Section 3.3.2 describe the instantaneous ability of a given architecture to generate payload wrenches and identify configurations that are close to kinematic singularities. However, these indices are evaluated under static or quasi-static assumptions and therefore cannot fully characterize the behavior of the closed-loop system during motion. During motion, cable directions, tensions and payload dynamics continuously evolve. Consequently, a configuration that appears favorable according to static indices may still exhibit oscillations, poor tracking or instability. Closed-loop simulation is therefore necessary to verify whether the theoretical advantages translate into practical performance.

All simulations are carried out using the MuJoCo (Multi-Joint Dynamics with Contact) physics extensions, allowing simulation of closed-loop systems, such as CDPRs and ACTSs, which is not possible in Gazebo. Another reason I switched from Gazebo to MuJoCo was the ability to model cables as tendons, which are minimum-path-length strings with wrapping and tracking, constraints [21]. However, for the purpose of this thesis, the cables are treated as pure physical constraints, without stiffness or damping.

The payload mass, UAV model, controller gains, drone cable lengths, simulation duration, and desired payload pose are kept constant throughout all experiments to ensure a fair comparison between different architectural configurations. The only variables that change from one experiment to another are the cable routing, the UAV attachment geometry, and the placement of the ground hook points.

Two desired payload poses are taken in considerations. In the first scenario, the desired payload orientation coincides with the world reference frame; while in the other scenario a non-zero desired orientation is imposed. This allows to analyze separately the rotational motions from the translation tracking.

First, the classical Stewart configuration is analyzed and used as a reference architecture due to its geometric symmetry and extensive use in the literature. In fact, if even Stewart-like performs poorly, the problem is likely the controller rather than the architecture. The remaining experiments then investigate how modifications to the ground cable routing, UAV attachment geometry, and hook placement affect both the theoretical performance indices and the closed-loop behavior of the system. This progressive analysis makes it possible to identify which geometric features have the greatest influence on payload manipulation performance.

Simulation results

How to structure this chapter:

1. Why did we chose to go for the method: controller and see if that pose is reacheable? [DONE]
2. Talk about Stewart configurations,
 - which are the indices values [DONE]
 - what these can tell us about everything [DONE]
 - How do I want each performance index? [DONE]
 - Show them in a graph
3. Given an UAV configuration (we chose triangle), analyze cable routing
 - Why we choose the triangle for the UAVs configuration? [DONE]
 - How the code work, how a given cable routing has been found [DONE]
 - How the results before simulation and after simulation differ?
 - Why we need to test it dynamically and not just trust the results we obtain before? [DONE, add table]
 - Rectangle-same really unstable configuration
 - line or diagonal results in not-feasible configurations, why? what does this mean? Add geometric reasons
4. Given the results of the previous step, lets analyze the first 3/5 configurations with all 6 possible uav configurations
 - Expetation: triangle being the best one, if not, which one is best? Rerun step 2 and see how things change
 - How drone attachment influences reaching the goal? Show evolution graph
5. Can a more spread-out hook configuration on the ground better the performance or it is irrelevant?
 - Does the answer change when the desired position is If so, it opens results to the moving hook point.further away?
 - Show example on the top configuration and a really bad one.

- Is there any papers/theorem that says so?
 - Show evolution graph
6. How a configuration far away from the hook point on the ground performs?
- (a) What Stewart does and what top configuration does
 - (b) The hook position should cover more space on the ground. Does this better the result stewart vs top configuration?
 - (c) Is there a geometric reason/ theory for that?

6.1 Stewart platform baseline

Thanks to its symmetrical geometry, the Stewart ground cable configuration is expected to ensure uniform torque generation in all directions while maintaining an optimal distance from singularities. Consequently, high values of the manipulability, capacity margin, radius of available wrench, and composite score are expected, together with a relatively high conditioning index. From a control perspective, these characteristics should result in accurate payload tracking while maintaining all cable tensions within their admissible limits.

6.1.1 Numerical Verification of the Implementation

Before comparing different ACTS architectures, one representative Stewart configuration is manually verified. The optimized cable tensions, payload wrench and UAV thrusts are recomputed directly from the governing equations presented in Chapter 2 and compared with the values returned by the implementation. This verification confirms the correctness of the numerical optimization and the controller implementation before performing the comparative study.

Configuration

Payload dimensions $2.0 \times 2.0 \times 0.2$

Desired pose $p^* = [0.5, -0.5, 2.0]^\top$

Desired orientation $R^* = \mathbb{I}$

Desired payload wrench $W_p^* = [0, 0, -9.21, 0, 0, 0]^\top$

attachment		hook points	
$A_4 \equiv A_5$	$[0.0, 1.1, 0.0]^\top$	$B_4 \equiv B_9$	$[0.5, 0.05, 1.9]^\top$
$A_6 \equiv A_7$	$[-0.9526, -0.55, 0.0]^\top$	$B_5 \equiv B_6$	$[-0.0237, -0.775, 1.9]^\top$
$A_8 \equiv A_9$	$[0.9526, -0.55, 0.0]^\top$	$B_7 \equiv B_8$	$[0.9763, -0.775, 1.9]^\top$

Using Equation 3.6b , the cable directions u_i are:

$$\begin{aligned} u_4 &= [-0.2245, 0.4713, -0.8529]^\top & u_7 &= [-0.7100, 0.0828, -0.6993]^\top \\ u_5 &= [-0.0089, 0.7024, -0.7117]^\top & u_8 &= [-0.0124, 0.1176, -0.9930]^\top \\ u_6 &= [-0.4545, 0.1047, -0.8846]^\top & u_9 &= [0.2215, -0.2937, -0.9299]^\top \end{aligned}$$

$$J_{p,ground} = \begin{bmatrix} -0,22445 & 0,47135 & -0,85291 & -0,42197 & 0,02245 & 0,12345 \\ -0,00888 & 0,70238 & -0,71175 & 0,26597 & -0,33812 & 0,33656 \\ -0,45452 & 0,10475 & -0,88456 & 0,25373 & -0,37586 & 0,29632 \\ -0,70998 & 0,08282 & -0,69934 & 0,20060 & 0,40409 & -0,52834 \\ -0,01239 & 0,11759 & -0,99298 & 0,28483 & 0,47420 & -0,47636 \\ 0,22151 & -0,29365 & -0,92989 & -0,54081 & -0,02215 & -0,12183 \end{bmatrix}$$

But I don't know where the drones may be, so what to do? I can do the same and compute also the cable vector for the drone cable and its respective jacobian

$$u_1 =$$

$$u_2 =$$

$$u_3 =$$

$$J_{p,drones} \Leftarrow [$$

Payload wrench W_p

Cable tensions τ_i

Required drone thrust

Does it correspond

6.1.2 Comparison $\tau_{\min}$ and τ_{opt}

As mentioned in Section 4.2, we evaluate two distinct tension allocation strategies:

- Minimal tension strategy, in which a minimum cable tension is imposed to each cable tension such that $\|\tau_i\| = \tau_{\min}$.
- Optimal tension strategy, in which cable tensions are determined by the quadratic optimization problem in Equation 4.29

The performance indices and tracking errors under both strategies across three operational scenarios are summarized in Table 6.1.

Even though being faster, the minimal tension strategy has negative consequences on the system's robustness. By locking all cable tensions to their absolute lowest limit ($\tau_{\min}$), the range of available tension choices shrinks to a single point. As a result, the controller loses its ability to adjust forces, reducing the payload's Available Wrench Set (AWS) to just a single fixed outcome. [22] As a result, any deviation of the desired payload wrench W_p^* from this single point results in a negative capacity margin (as seen in Scenario A where $\gamma = -0.65562$). This indicates that the system is theoretically incapable of resisting external disturbances or maintaining equilibrium without violating the tension constraints.

Switching to the optimal tension allocation, allows the cable tensions to vary dynamically between $\tau_{\min}$ and $\tau_{\max}$. As a result, the radius of the Available Wrench increases and the capacity margin takes on a positive value ($\gamma = 3.74947$). Thus, also the composite score increases. Differently, changing the tension allocation algorithm has no effect on the conditioning index or manipulability because they are kinematic metrics that only depend on the platform's geometric position.

Give examples

Because this study focuses on offline structural and kinematic analysis rather than real-time control, the extra computation time does not compromise our findings. For future real-time applications, this hierarchical formulation can be mapped to more efficient schemes.

On the other hand, it is worth to notice that, since the objective function does not contain any state-tracking terms, this optimizer does not directly minimize the payload's real-time position or orientation tracking errors. Because of this, a spatial configuration

Metric / Parameter	Scenario A		Scenario B	
	$\tau_{\min}$	τ_{opt}	$\tau_{\min}$	τ_{opt}
Desired Position	$[0.5, -0.5, 2.0]^\top$		$[0.5, -0.5, 2.0]^\top$	
Desired Orientation	$[1.0, 0.0, 0.0, 0.0]^\top$		$[1.0, 0.1, 0.1, 0.1]^\top$	
Conditioning Index	0.10256	0.09621	0.07639	0.06621
Manipulability	0.47759	0.43684	0.36192	0.30017
Radius Avail. Wrench	16.46686	19.52504	18.66125	20.29844
Capacity Margin	-0.65562	3.74947	-1.93639	2.28516
Worst-case CM	0.86233	0.63971	0.86253	0.67165
Composite Score	5.55786	7.97141	5.86246	7.75175
Position Error	0.00209	0.00285	0.00183	0.00271
Orientation Error	0.00125	0.00200	0.00127	0.00299

Table 6.1: Comparative performance indices and tracking errors for Stewart baseline configuration across Scenarios A and B.

that yields globally minimal propulsion effort does not guarantee a minimum in tracking error.

Although the Stewart configuration exhibits good overall performance and provides an excellent reference architecture, the proposed ACTS differs from a classical Stewart platform because the UAV cables can be connected to the payload in several different ways. Moreover, different ground cable routings may further improve specific performance aspects such as stability, wrench generation capability, or robustness. For these reasons, the Stewart configuration is adopted as a baseline against which all alternative architectures are compared.

An ideal ACTS architecture should remain far from singular configurations, generate payload wrenches efficiently in every direction, and maintain sufficient redundancy to accommodate disturbances while respecting cable tension limits. Consequently, all the considered performance indices should be as big as possible.

The considerations from now on will be done using the optimal tension strategy.

6.2 Ground cable routing

Once the controller has been validated using the Stewart baseline, we can proceed to consider different ways to connect six ground cables to the platform (Figure 6.2) and the drone (Figure 6.3). The same ground configuration hook-anchor can change the system’s stability based on which hook is connected to which anchor point on the ground. Therefore, we will start considering the drone attachment configuration as fixed to the triangular arrangement and vary only the routing of the six ground cables. This specific UAV configuration is chosen because it provides a symmetric distribution of the three drones around the payload. This approach allows one to isolate the influence of the ground cable routing and attribute differences in performance solely to the ground architecture. Finally, in Section 6.4, the impact of various UAV attachment geometries is examined independently.

Focusing on the ground cable routing, there are at most $6! = 720$ physically distinct valid ways to route the six ground cables. Scoring an architecture using only one arbitrarily

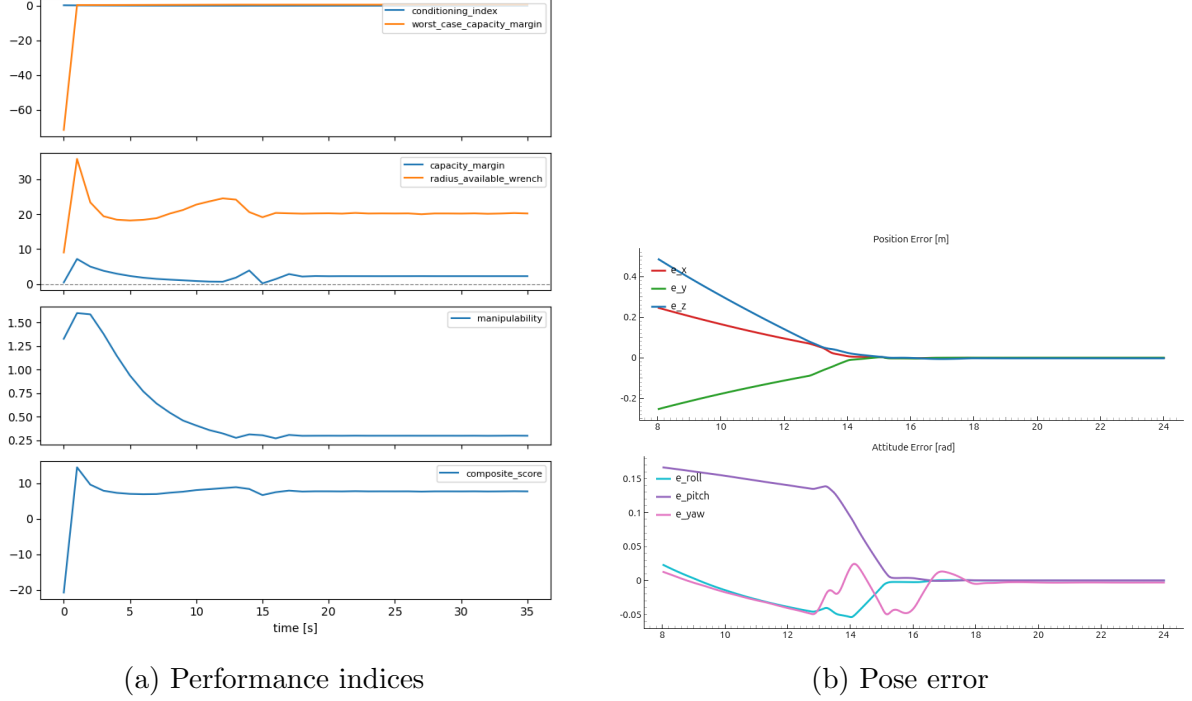


Figure 6.1: Graphs

chosen routing raise the question on how lucky the routing choice was and how good the architecture actually is.

To eliminate this source of bias, an exhaustive routing search is performed for every pair of payload and ground layouts. All physically valid routings are enumerated while respecting the maximum cable capacity of each attachment point. For every routing, the corresponding payload Jacobian J_p is constructed according to Equation 3.7, and the routing is evaluated over a representative set of payload poses. At each pose, the routing must satisfy the necessary conditions introduced in Section 3.3.2. Routings that fail any of these conditions are discarded. Among the surviving candidates, the routing is assigned its worst-case performance across all poses, and the architecture is finally characterized by the routing that maximizes the conditioning index. In this way, architectures are compared according to their best achievable routing rather than to an arbitrary cable assignment. Architectures are subsequently ranked against one another by worst-case conditioning index.

Update with correct datas

Pay. Layout	Gnd. Layout	N_{rout}	N_{pos}	Feas.	ν	w	$\sigma_{\min}$	$\sigma_{\max}$	Rank	Best Routing
2X3	pentagon	360	8	✓	0.1402	0.3680	0.3275	2.3452	✓	A-E-B-A-C-D-D-C-E-B-F-E
two-triangles	pentagon	360	8	✓	0.1383	0.2169	0.3241	2.3566	✓	A-E-B-A-C-C-D-D-E-B-F-E
pentagon	2X3	360	8	✓	0.1354	0.3773	0.3169	2.3401	✓	A-A-B-F-C-E-D-B-E-C-E-D
hexagon	pyramid	720	8	✓	0.1343	0.1664	0.3180	2.3794	✓	A-D-B-A-C-B-D-E-E-F-F-C
pentagon	pentagon	168	8	✓	0.1316	0.2494	0.2899	2.3420	✓	A-E-B-C-C-B-D-E-E-A-E-D

Table 6.2: Ground Cable Routing and Layout Performance Analysis

The composite score N is not used for ranking routings during the exhaustive search because it requires information that is only available after solving the tension planner, such as the optimal cable tensions and the available wrench set. Computing its capacity-

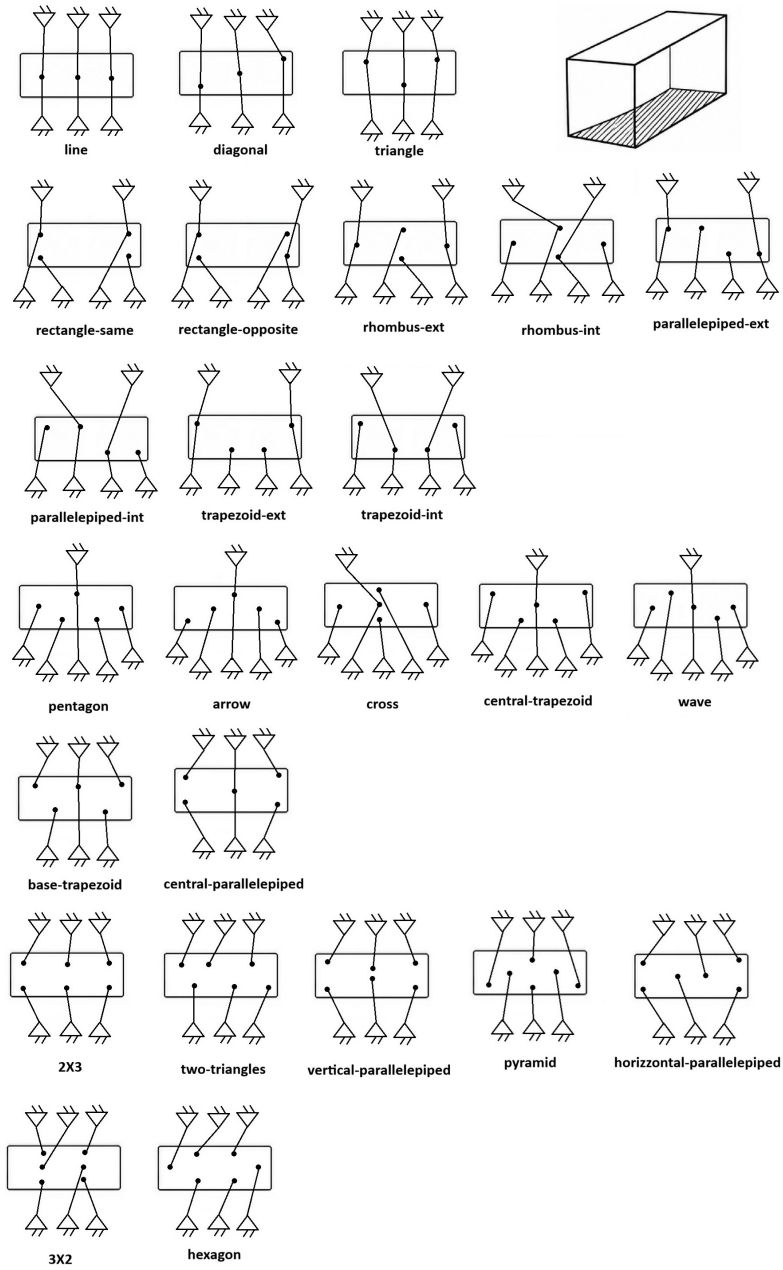


Figure 6.2: Possible 6 UGVs connections

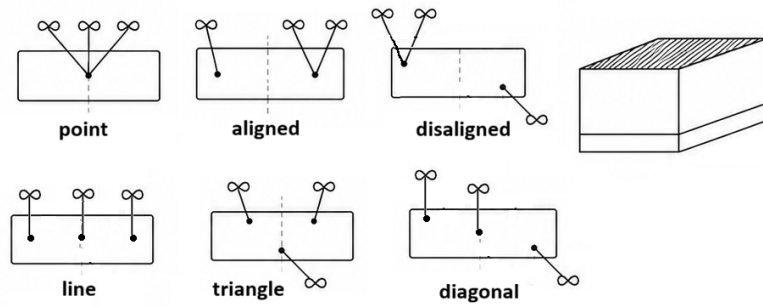


Figure 6.3: Possible 3 UAVs connection with one cable

based terms is also computationally expensive and unreliable near singular configurations. Additionally, its weighting factors have not been experimentally validated, making it unsuitable for selecting the best routing. Instead, the search uses the conditioning index (with manipulability as a supporting metric), as it is a parameter-free, geometry-based measure that can be efficiently computed directly from the Jacobian. The composite score and capacity-based metrics are therefore evaluated later during closed-loop simulations, once a routing and tension solution are available.

Algorithm 1 Cable Routing Optimization and Architecture Ranking

```

1: for all (payload_layout, ground_layout) pairs do
2:   Enumerate every valid 6-cable routing
3:   for all routing do
4:     for all pose  $\in$  test-pose set do
5:       Build  $J_p$   $\triangleright$  Eq. 3.7
6:       Check Wrench Closure  $\triangleright \text{rank}(J_p) = 6$ 
7:       Check Wrench Feasibility  $\triangleright 0 \leq \tau_{\min} \leq \tau \leq \tau_{\max}$ 
8:       Check Interference-Freedom  $\triangleright$  Eq. 3.19
9:     end for
10:    Record this routing's worst-case score across all poses
11:  end for
12:  Keep the best surviving routing for this architecture
13: end for

```

Come posso sapere se una configurazione è più suscettibile a singolarità ad occhio?

line or diagonal results in not-feasible configurations, why? what does this mean?
Geometric reasons?

The line and diagonal configurations approach kinematic or wrench singularities, where the cable arrangement cannot generate the desired six-dimensional wrench while maintaining positive tensions. Conversely, the Rectangle-Same configuration remains kinematically feasible but exhibits poor rotational stiffness due to its asymmetric cable pairing. As a result, although the Jacobian remains full rank, the payload develops a rocking motion that cannot be predicted by the geometric performance indices alone.

The theoretical indices evaluate the geometric and static properties of a cable routing. They identify configurations that are close to kinematic or wrench singularities and rank architectures according to their ability to generate payload wrenches. However, they cannot predict the transient response of the closed-loop system. Dynamic effects such as payload inertia, controller gains and load redistribution are only captured by simulation. Consequently, while poor theoretical indices almost always indicate poor dynamic performance, the opposite is not necessarily true: a routing with good static indices may still exhibit oscillations or poor tracking.

Insert table comparing the two

Rectangle-same really unstable configuration

The Jacobian is full rank and the static indices are acceptable, yet the payload rocks because of an uneven load distribution and poor torsional stiffness. That example provides strong evidence that the theoretical indices are necessary but not sufficient for predicting closed-loop behavior.

talk about triangle-triangle combination

Other combinations that give interesting results?

6.3 Ground anchor placement

Increasing the spacing between the ground hooks enlarges the available wrench set and moves the system farther from wrench singularities, explaining the observed improvement in tracking performance.

6.4 Drone hook placement

Add link to the repository

Conclusions

Future developments

- Consider different configuration rather than 6 on the ground and 3 on the top
- Façade interaction

Also answering these questions:

- Is it better having the drone connected through one or two cables to the payload in terms of easy maneuverability, feasible workspace, available wrench set and energy consumption?
- How accuracy on drones' position affects the accuracy on the platform's position?
- Are UAVs (resp. UGVs) strictly connected to the upper (resp. down) face or can they be attached to the down (resp. upper) face?

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Singularities and Performance Indices

write it better

Cable-driven parallel robots (CDPRs) and aerial cable-driven systems experience critical operating limits where force transmission or controllability degrades. Table A.1 summarizes these operational singularities and their physical consequences.

Type	Cause	Detection Index	Consequence
Kinematic	$\text{rank}(J_p) < 6$	Condition Number, Manipulability	Loss of platform Degrees of Freedom (DoF)
Wrench	Desired wrench outside AWS	Capacity Margin, RAW	Target wrench cannot be generated
Tension	Negative or zero cable tensions	Tension optimization	Cable slack / loss of constraint
Stiffness	Poor cable distribution	Stiffness Matrix, Simulation	Unwanted oscillations and rocking
Dynamic	Closed-loop instability	Eigenvalues, Simulation	Trajectory tracking failure

Table A.1: Classification of Singularity Types in Cable-Driven Parallel Systems